> The long continued darkness and silence in our camp greatly puzzled the Afghans, especially as we did not attempt to return their fire. Imagining we had either run away or that their fierce fire 'had sent all the sons of burned fathers to Jehunnum,' they moved down the hill in two bodies to spoil the camp and slay the wounded, their progress being accompanied by fierce yells and shouts . . .
>
> [Finally] we could just see them looming through the gloom. The men of my two companies had been sitting down on the ground, with their muskets between their knees, but the short word 'Ready!' brought them to the kneeling position; and at the word 'Present!' a volley from 170 men crashed amongst the enemy with awful effect . . . We had some forty men killed and wounded, and but for our colonel's presence of mind and foresight, our loss would have been trebled.[64]

When Macnaghten heard about the ambush he was furious. 'Imagine the impudence of the rascals,' he wrote. 'Taking up a position with four or five hundred men in the Khoord-Kabul Pass, not fifteen miles from the capital.' 'Fighting Bob' Sale was promptly sent off on 12 October with the rest of his brigade – around 1,600 men in all – to relieve the advance guard and reopen the passes.

Their first night at the mouth of the pass was quiet, and the following morning they marched at dawn into the narrow winding heights of the Khord Kabul. 'No opposition met them until they were fairly entangled in the pass,' remembered the chaplain, the Rev. G. R. Gleig, who was planning to return to India with the brigade.

> Then from the rocks and precipices on either side, such a storm of fire opened as told of itself that the heights above were occupied in great force. So skilful too were the Afghans in the art of skirmishing, that, except by the flashes which their matchlocks emitted, it was impossible to tell where the marksmen lay. Rocks and stones, some of them hardly larger than a thirteen-inch shell, seemed to offer them excellent shelter. They squatted down showing nothing above the crag except the long barrels of their fusils and the tops of their turbans; and with such unerring aim were their shots thrown that, both in the advance guard, and from the body of the column, men began to drop.[65]

It was already becoming clear, as an official report to Calcutta pointed out, that in the high passes 'our regular European and Hindoostanee Troops fight against Afghans in their native hills to a great disadvantage. The superior agility of the latter enables them to evade pursuit and their jezails or long guns carry with deadly precision to a distance where our muskets are harmless.'[66] The ability of the Afghans to melt invisibly into the landscape also alarmed the British; as Sale reported to his wife, 'until they